match 6–3 and, in my third match, worked to a position where I was leading 5–3 and 40–30 in the ninth and last game.

'I've got *balle de match*, Ma,' I yelled. 'I've got *balle de match*!'

My mother was helping to organise the tournament, sitting some distance away, but she heard my raised voice and came running to the courtside. I saw her arrive. This was fun.

My next forehand hit the net.

'Don't go, Ma,' I said, 'it's now *egalite*.'

It may seem odd that this highly excitable Afrikaans-speaking six-year-old boy should be competing in a tennis event in Nelspruit and speaking French but there was a simple explanation: only the previous week, we had been watching the French Open on television and I had learned to mimic the umpires at Roland Garros.

The next point was won, securing a 6–3 win and, somehow, I managed to win each of my remaining matches in the tournament. A very happy boy smiled throughout the long drive home.

Encouraged by this success, I started to spend more and more time playing tennis, walking to the sports club in town almost every day to hit some balls for an hour or so. I needed a training partner to hit the balls back and none of my friends were keen but, happily, my extraordinary mother almost always said yes.

A Canadian actor called Victor Webster has been quoted as saying: 'If you throw a pebble in the water on one side of the ocean, you can create a tidal wave on the other side.' The idea that a tiny and seemingly insignificant event can have enormous consequences may seem foolish but, in my experience, it is proven.

This is what happened.

A young and very small boy living in a small town in rural South Africa during the late 1980s starts to play tennis and appears able to hit the ball relatively well. So what? Not a lot, I suppose. There are literally millions of youngsters who show some degree of sporting ability at an early age.